Error Messages & Validation

Abi Harrison-Nye

What is it for?

Form errors are a major barrier for all users, but they can completely block users with disabilities. Inaccessible errors include:

- Just highlighting a field in red is useless for screen reader users and people with colour blindness
- Vague messages like 'Invalid input' or 'Error' tell the user nothing about how to fix it
- When a form fails to submit, screen reader users are often left at the top of the page, not knowing what or where the error is

How to support it

- Be specific. Don't say 'Invalid', instead say something like 'Please enter a valid email address'
- Don't use colour alone, always add a text message and/or an accessible icon next to the field
- Connect the error. Use `aria-describedby` to link the input field to its error message
- Manage focus. If a form fails to submit, move focus to the first field with an error
- Use `aria-invalid="true"` on the field so assistive technology knows it has an error

Useful Links

W3C WAI - Validating Input

Level Access - Designer Tips: Creating Accessible Forms